

Silk Road

By Nick Middleton

The lesson 'Silk Road'

- an extract from the author's travelogue
- describes only a small part of his journey
- journey from Ravu, a small mountain village to Darchen, at the foot of Mt. Kailash

Lahmo gives a farewell present to author, a long sleeved sheep skin coat. Worn by men.

- The author left Ravu in the company of Daniel and Tsetan.
- Tsetan knew a short-cut. He said the journey would be smooth if there was no snow.
- From the gently rolling hills of Ravu they took a short through cut.
- On the way they saw a few gazelles and a herd of wild asses.
- passing by the hills they could see the lonely drokbas tending their flocks.
- Men and women would pause and stare at their car, occasionally waving as they passed by.
- passing by nomad's tents, saw Tibetan mastiffs who would explode into action as they neared the tents, barked furiously, were fearless, would chase the car for some distance, then would go back at 5210 meters above the sea level, the road became bumpier icy top layer of the snow was very dangerous; the car could slip off the road snow continued blocking their way when reached 5515 meters above the sea level 1. atmospheric pressure became very low,

2. Tsetan opened the lid of the petrol tank to release the evaporated fuel 3. author experienced severe headache

- by late afternoon, reached the small town of Hor, grim, miserable place on shores of lake Mansarovar

- no vegetation, just dust and rocks

- Mansarovar a source of four main Indian rivers-the Indus, the Ganges, the Sutlej and

the Brahmaputra." Hor was a grim, miserable place. There was reached a guest house in Darchen by 10.30 p.m

author had a very troubled night, sinus blocked, not able to get enough oxygen, found difficulty in sleeping

- Next day Tsetan took him to the Darchen Medical College

- Doctor told him it was just cold and the altitude, gave him some medicine, slept well that night

- like Hor, Darchen was dusty, heaps of refuse seen all around, not many shops, appeared to be sparsely populated

- Author felt lonely as no pilgrims could be seen, had reached there very early in the season

Meeting Norbu:

- Author wanted to reach Mount Kailash to do kora

- But didn't want to do it alone

- was looking for someone who could speak or understand English. Found Norbu in a cafe

- saw him reading an English book

- He was a Tibetan, worked in Beijing at the Chinese Academy of Social Sciences
- He too was there to do kora, but not a religious person
- Both decided to climb Mount Kailash
- Norbu became an ideal companion for author

Q.1. Ans. Who was Lhamo? What farewell gift did she give to author?

Lhamo was a Tibetan woman who had set up a tent for pilgrims near Ravu. She was honest and helpful. She offered a long sleeved sheep skin coat as a farewell gift.

Q.2. Ans. Who did the party come across after leaving Ravu? From the gently rolling hills of Ravu, the author's car came to vast open plains. They saw a few antelopes grazing and further on, they saw a herd of wild ass raising a pall of dust. As the car approached them, they galloped away.

Q.3. Where did the narrator meet Norbu? How could he be a help to the narrator?

Ans. The narrator met Norbu in a cafe. He was Tibetan, and worked in Beijing at the Chinese Academy of Social Sciences, in the Institute of Ethnic Literature. He had come to do the kora.

Norbu had been writing academic papers about the Kailash Kora and its importance in various works of Buddhist literature for many years but. He had never actually done it himself. The narrator was relieved to team up with him. He would not be alone then.

Q.4. Where did the narrator find Dorokbas? What did he notice about them?

Ans. As the narrator went further up the hills from the rocky wasteland, he noticed the solitary drokbas tending their flocks. Sometimes these well-wrapped figures would halt briefly and stare at their car. They seldom waved as they crossed. When the road took them close to the sheep, the animals would swerve away from the speeding car,

Q.5. The narrator was fascinated by the huge Tibetan mastiffs. Why ?

Ans. Crossing the nomads' dark tents pitched in remoteness, the narrator noticed that a huge black dog, a Tibetan mastiff, guarded most of the tents. These monstrous creatures would tilt their great big heads when someone moved towards them. As they drew closer, these dogs would race straight towards them, like a bullet from a gun. These dogs were pitch black and usually wore bright red collars. They barked furiously with their gigantic jaws and were so fearless that they ran straight into the path of their vehicle. They would chase them for about a hundred metres. The narrator could understand why Tibetan mastiffs became popular in China's imperial courts as hunting dogs.

Q6. Why did Tsetan stop? How did he maneuver across the first patch of snow that they came across?

Tsetan stopped at a tight bend and got out because the snow had covered the path in front of them. This unexpected-depository was too steep for their vehicle to

mount. Tsetan stepped on to the covered snow, and stamped his foot to determine how sturdy it was. The snow was not deep but the car could turn over. Tsetan took handfuls of dirt and threw them across the frozen surface. Daniel and the narrator, too, joined in. When the snow was spread with soil, Tsetan backed up the vehicle and drove towards the dirty snow. The car moved across the icy surface without noticeable difficulty.

Q7. Why was the narrator sorry to see the miserable plight of Hor?

Hor was a dismal place with no vegetation. It was only dust and rocks coupled with years of accumulated refuse. He found this unfortunate because this town was on the banks of Lake Mansarovar, Tibet's most venerated stretch of water.

Q8. 'Darchen didn't look so horrible after a good night's sleep'. Justify

Ans. The narrator had a very uncomfortable night at Darchen. After he rested, although Darchen was dusty, with heaps of rubble and refuse, the bright sun in a clear blue sky gave the narrator a view of the Himalayas. He also noticed the huge, snow-capped mountain, Gura Mandhata, with just a tuft of cloud suspended over its peak.